

GENDER

Suchitra Shetty Vs. Ajeya Row



This time we thought we'd just sit back and let Suchitra and Ajeya create avatars. We chose Yahoo!—<http://avatar.yahoo.com>—since it allows a lot of customisation.

BENDERS



The first thing for Suchitra was the background rather than the avatar, and that was fixed at the outset. Browsing through numerous bags, she seemed half-happy with a small black leather bag, which she added to her avatar. And then, she changed her mind (they've just got to, you should know): she replaced it with a tiger-skin bag. Continuing with the accessories, Suchitra chose a long, striped scarf.

So what was the "Branded" tab? Simple—it was about actual brands, we informed her. Here she selected the Dodge Nitro with a black city background (flashy again). We knew that deep down, somewhere, she wasn't happy with the earlier background. Another change of mind followed, and she reverted to the leather bag (to go with the background).



When we told Ajeya about the exciting things he was being called upon to do, he warned us that he wasn't a designer, and that we shouldn't hope for anything good-looking. He went on to try and figure what each button on the default page was for, and it was clear he was creating an avatar for the first time. (Actually, not too many of us have bothered, either.) We let him do the hard work—Ajeya read everything on the page, and clicking a few images, he figured how the default avatar could be changed. (Suchitra gets the points here.)



THE US WILL RETAIN CONTROL

The ITU's Being Deferential

The Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers (ICANN) is a US non-profit company that manages the top-level domain name addressing system. ICANN reports to the US Commerce Department, which has extended ICANN's control for at least three more years.

Opposition to this US control of the Internet comes from Brazil, Iran, Cuba, and a number of other poor or developing countries. There have been calls for an internationally-accountable body to take over the role of overseeing the Internet, and the International Telecommunications Union (ITU), a UN agency, is one of the few such bodies.

A "solution" is hardly in clear sight. Hamadoun Toure is the new head of the ITU, and he has said that he has no plans to take a bigger role in regulating and governing the Internet. The ITU stepping in *could*

mean less US control. In a Reuters report, Toure said, "We must avoid setting up a superstructure which would be very controversial and very difficult to put into effect." The countries mentioned are likely not too happy with this pronouncement: a "superstructure" to oversee the Internet could be exactly what they're pitching for.

Toure said the ITU would instead focus on tackling cyber-security, and in narrowing the digital divide between rich and poor countries. Amongst Toure's other priorities are standards for broadband Internet access and for 3G mobile phone accessibility.

Analysts had foreseen that Internet control passing on to a body more global in nature would not happen any time soon, and Toure is just reinforcing that.

The world is divided in opinion—some countries such as Australia are perfectly fine with US control, but at the other end of the spectrum is Iran, which actually once expressed fears that the US could block Internet access in the country whenever it wanted to.

HD-DVD PROTECTION ALREADY CRACKED

The Pirate Bay's Victory Dance

Of course we knew it would happen. We did not know the

how and the when, but HD-DVD has been cracked, and HD-DVD rips are available on P2P, courtesy—no surprises—The Pirate Bay.

For those not in the know, The Pirate Bay is one of the best-known BitTorrent trackers. It has just enhanced its celebrity status by announcing the arrival of HD-DVD torrents. In addition, the Bay has serious political support in Sweden, and it has been harbouring plans of making a country for itself on a UK island.

"Yesterday the user Lyzz became historical by posting the first HD-DVD movie on our fine tracker," a recent blog post states. "It was the action sci-fi movie *The Chronicles of Riddick*, and today *Batman Begins* came along. They are about 20 GB each, so we recommend some fast broadband (moving to Sweden should take care of that) and a superfast computer to take care of the 1080p video."

There's some confusion about which the first movie was—some sources report that it was the sci-fi movie *Serenity*, made available as a .EVO file. Whichever way, the cracked movie can be played by most DVD-playing software.

Blu-ray discs will no doubt be cracked soon enough, although we must mention that the protection system on that format is more robust than that on HD-DVD.

What can the big labels be thinking? Take a look at our cover story for insight on the issue.

Buzzword of the MONTH

Apple iPhone

The much-anticipated Apple version of the mobile phone—the Apple iPhone—was announced at Macworld 2007. It is a next-gen multimedia phone running on a skimmed OS X; think of it as a widescreen iPod with Wi-Fi and Bluetooth, multi-touch input technology, and all the features of a smartphone. "Multi-touch input" means the user can navigate via finger gestures over the display. The camera on the phone is 2 MP. Jobs said the phone is

an "intelligent Internet communicator." Coolness indicator: a proximity sensor deactivates the screen when the phone is held next to the ear.

The iPhone syncs with iTunes and auto-syncs with a PC or Mac. It will hit US shelves in June, and will be available in Asia next year. Tech analysts are wondering, though, why the thing isn't 3G-enabled, why it's not white, and about incompatibility with third-party applications.